

Piano Lessons for Absolute Beginners

Lesson 8: Dynamics and Tempo

Dynamics and Tempo - Study Notes

Key Concepts

- **Dynamics:** The loudness or softness of music.
- **Tempo:** The speed of music.
- **Piano (p):** A dynamic marking indicating to play softly.
- **Forte (f):** A dynamic marking indicating to play loudly.
- **Beats Per Minute (BPM):** The unit used to measure tempo.

Summary

This lesson introduces two fundamental elements of musical expression: dynamics and tempo. Dynamics refer to how loud or soft the music should be played, adding emotional depth and contrast. Tempo, on the other hand, dictates the speed at which the music progresses, influencing the overall feel and energy. Understanding and controlling these elements allows musicians to communicate a wider range of emotions and create more engaging performances.

By experimenting with dynamics like *piano* (soft) and *forte* (loud), and varying the tempo (speed) of a piece, you can dramatically alter its character. Even a simple melody like "Hot Cross Buns" can sound completely different depending on how you interpret these markings. Using a metronome is a great way to ensure a steady and consistent tempo while practicing.

Important Points

- **Dynamics markings are abbreviations:** *p* = piano (soft), *f* = forte (loud). There are many other dynamic markings (see Further Reading), but these are the most common for beginners.
- **Tempo is measured in BPM:** A higher BPM means faster music, and a lower BPM means slower music.
- **A metronome helps maintain a consistent tempo:** It provides a steady beat to practice with.
- **Dynamics and tempo affect the *feel* of the music:** Soft and slow music can feel peaceful or sad, while loud and fast music can feel exciting or energetic.
- **Expression is key:** Dynamics and tempo are tools to add emotion and personality to your playing.

Examples

- **Example 1: "Hot Cross Buns" with Dynamics:** Play "Hot Cross Buns" first with a *p* (piano) marking. Focus on playing each note gently and softly. Then, play it again with an *f* (forte) marking, playing each note loudly and with more energy. Notice how the *p* version feels calmer and the *f* version feels more powerful.
- **Example 2: "Hot Cross Buns" with Tempo:** Set a metronome to 60 BPM (Beats Per Minute). Play "Hot Cross Buns" along with the metronome. Now, increase the metronome to 120 BPM and play it again. The music will sound significantly faster. Try slowing it down to 30 BPM – it will sound very slow and deliberate.

Quick Review

1. What does *p* stand for in musical notation, and what does it mean?
2. What is BPM, and what does it measure?
3. How does changing the tempo affect the overall feel of a piece of music?
4. Why is a metronome a useful tool for musicians?
5. Give an example of how dynamics can add expression to a simple melody.

Further Reading

- **Dynamic Markings:** Research other dynamic markings like *mp* (mezzo piano - moderately soft), *mf* (mezzo forte - moderately loud), *crescendo* (gradually getting louder), and *decrescendo* (gradually getting softer).
- **Tempo Markings:** Learn about tempo markings like *Allegro* (fast), *Andante* (walking pace), and *Adagio* (slow).
- **Metronome Apps:** Explore different metronome apps available for smartphones and tablets.
- **Listening Exercises:** Listen to different pieces of music and pay attention to how the composer uses dynamics and tempo to create different moods and effects.
- **Time Signatures:** Understanding time signatures will help you better grasp tempo and rhythm.

